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with data volumes over 10 terabytes, yet queries are served within sub-second response times,” explains Dhulipala.

HSearch was released as an OSS contribution from Bizosys under the liberal Apache 2.0 licence via Sourceforge in November 2010. There have been over 2000 developer downloads from 80+ countries worldwide over the past 3.5 years, with India, China, United States, Korea and Germany being the countries that logged the highest downloads. HSearch was benchmarked for its performance in May 2011 at Intel Labs.

FOSS: The scalable business model

Bizosys’ business model comprises a mix of professional services and solutions development. Two of the company’s subsequent offerings were in the data preparation/harvesting and real-time predictive analytics space. They leverage the open nature of HSearch, but include additional libraries and code that are specific to data extraction and transformation, as well as algorithms for predictive analytics applied to time-series data. These two solutions are commercial offerings. In its third commercial offering, HSearch is deployed as a big data store and is a more economical alternative to in-memory cache or traditional database-driven solutions.

HSearch is central to Bizosys’ business and the firm’s entire business comes from it, the core engine of which is an Apache licensed product, says Dhulipala.

HSearch is built on top of existing OSS products, primarily from Apache Foundation, to make Hadoop, which is a batch-oriented solution, into a real-time solution. Several enhancements bring it closer to enterprise requirements in terms of the scale, performance levels and security that it offers, on the IT side. And for business, rapid search, data exploration and analysis is what HSearch offers. Through its engagements with large and small enterprises, Bizosys has found that the number of organisations looking at open source and NoSQL offerings, for the benefits that products like HSearch and Hadoop address, is growing rapidly. “Product companies, primarily in the analytics space, that are confronted with the challenges of large volumes of unstructured data, query performance response times, etc, are also looking at the emerging Hadoop and NoSQL ecosystem for solutions. One CIO of a billion dollar group told Bizosys, ‘I want my data to be more ‘analysable.’ There has

been an explosion in an organisation’s own internal data — a surfeit of machine data, meta data, emails and user-generated content, etc,” quips Dhulipala.

According to him, these companies are looking at startups to provide them with innovative solutions. “A large financial MNC has launched an internal initiative that actively seeks to replace any COTS product with an OSS product, wherever suitable. OSS software companies such as Red Hat, etc, have set the right precedent by making OSS acceptable to enterprise IT. HSearch from Bizosys is not an exception here, and serves its own target audience in the big data space by having a core OSS offering,” adds Dhulipala.

For Bizosys, adopting OSS from organisations such as the Apache Foundation was clearly an engineering and business choice. From the engineering perspective, Hadoop evolved from addressing non-enterprise problems (having emerged out of a Google paper). As a business decision, being a startup, Bizosys was keen on keeping its operating expenses low so OSS was the best choice, especially under a liberal Apache licence. And it was also keen on contributing back in some measure. HSearch was, in fact, a contribution made back to the community even before Bizosys arrived at its current business model.

A growth story for others to emulate

So what has Bizosys’ growth been like over the past few years? Are there plans for expansion in the near future? “The last two years have been more business focused — we plan to grow as an advanced analytics company in the big data space offering superior scale and performance advantages for customers. Bizosys is currently focused on strengthening its sales side to achieve aggressive topline revenue growth. And through targeted engagements, the firm plans to enhance HSearch with new features or functions that add value to the core product,” says Dhulipala.

And how does it work — does the company approach a firm and counsel them to try its open source solutions or is it the other way round? How does Bizosys convince an IT manager or a CIO who’s wondering if this is the right time to deploy open source solutions? Dhulipala elaborates, “The advantage of going with an OSS approach is that, in certain situations, we found that the client side IT team was already aware of HSearch (to our surprise) and that helped build the credibility factor. In fact, in one meeting facilitated by our partner, Microsoft Azure, when the HSearch slide came up, the prospect asked us to skip it as his team was aware of it!”

Anecdotes apart, OSS is a key part of Bizosys’ strategy, primarily because it removes the conflict of interests when discussing IT solutions with customers. “Clients are assured that the product that best serves their requirements or the use case at hand, will be used,” shares Dhulipala.

Bizosys has worked with legal experts specialising